Everyone would then perform the kornish, bowing low, with the right hand placed on the head, and then settle down on to the rich, vibrant carpets that covered the floors. Jugs of drinks and other delicacies would be arranged on trays and platters and placed in front of the men and incense would burn in fragrant, wispy plumes. A favourite cheetah, jewelled collar gleaming in the flames of the candles, would watch the proceedings with an unblinking gaze while dogs would roam the courtyards. ‘His Majesty likes this animal very much for his excellent qualities and imports dogs from all countries,’ wrote Abu’l Fazl, adding that the best dogs were to be obtained from Kabul. Men with hawks on their arms would stand by and if the meetings were taking place at night, the water in the Anuptalao would reflect the perfect fractal geometry of the moonlight.

Akbar had also recently revived the ancient custom of sajda, or full body prostration, in court. He had renamed it zaminbos, kissing the ground, but even rebaptized, it caused revulsion amongst the orthodox theologians who had already had to tolerate a great deal of erosion in their power. Abu’l Fazl fumed that they were ‘ignorant ones’ who did not realize that this was a source of blessing and not, as they railed, worship before God. But Akbar quickly conceded the point and allowed zaminbos only to his closest disciples, in private.

In the darbar, meanwhile, Akbar attended to matters that were brought before him. In the diwan-e-khas, surrounded by his favourite noblemen and greatest courtiers, Akbar was relaxed and indulgent. He sat cross-legged, often wearing a dhoti of fine silk rather than the usual payjamas. The courtiers sat on their heels, hands placed decorously on their knees but the atmosphere was often easy-going and engaged. There would be Birbal, a paan tucked into his cheek, eyes sparkling and ready with a spirited remark. Aziz, deep-set eyes critical below his arched eyebrows, but affectionate and sincere. Todar Mal, sober and erudite, Man Singh, sun-scorched from his numerous campaigns, and always Abu’l Fazl, with his immense learning and keen intellect, constantly watching the Padshah, assessing, analysing, and translating everything that he saw around him. Rather discordant in this gathering of smooth courtiers was the Sayyid Mahmud of Baraha, considered ‘a man of rustic habits, and great personal generosity’. While the other courtiers sometimes sniggered at his lack of social graces and plain-speaking, Akbar recognized the great courage and loyalty of the man and rewarded him accordingly.